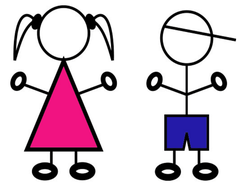
GENDER DIFFERENCES IN THE SCHOOL SUCCESS OF YOUNG HOMELESS CHILDREN

TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR
POST-BACCALAUREATE
ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM



Schevita Persaud, McNair Scholar
Professor Ann Masten Ph.D., Institute of Child Development

ABSTRACT

Effects of gender differences in the school success of young homeless children were examined using data from 53 children and their parents staying in an emergency shelter. Teacher reports of adaptation in school were obtained after the children began kindergarten or first grade. Based upon previous research, it was hypothesized that teachers would report girls as having higher academic competence, closer relationships with the teacher, less externalizing behavior, and less conflict than boys. Gender and grade were examined in order to assess whether potential favorable differences would be initially greater for girls due to an initial maturational lag for boys, that could be improved through the socialization in attending school. Results indicated that parent reports of externalizing behaviors predict teacher-child relationships; however, gender differences were not observed.

BACKGROUND

- There are early achievement gaps with girls outperforming boys on a variety of measures of school success. This is at times attributed to girls' higher internalizing behavior and boys' higher externalizing behavior[1].
- Girls' achievement is higher in primary school but advantage disappears in adolescence[2].
- Students from lower socioeconomic backgrounds tend to choose education tracks that offer less opportunities for economic success[3].
- Positive relationships with teachers are correlated with motivation and school success suggesting support systems are important for developmental outcomes[4].
- Protective factors (extracurricular activities) and risk factors (child abuse) predict academic performance. High risk predicts low academic performance yet protective factors help raise it[5].

RESEARCH QUESTIONS AND HYPOTHESES

Q1: Do teachers report gender differences in the school success of young homeless students?
H1: Teachers will rate girls as having greater school success than boys. Specifically, teachers will report that girls have better academic competence, closer relationships with teachers, lower eternalizing behaviors, and less conflict. Boys will have more externalizing and achievement problems and greater conflict.

Q2: Are gender differences greater in kindergarten?
H2: Gender differences will be more prominent, in favor of girls, in kindergarten than first grade.



Photos courtesy of Kendra Mack, 2008

METHOD

Participants and procedures

Children residing in emergency family shelter (*N=53)*
- ➢ 35 boys, 18 girls
- ➢ 79% of the children were African American, 1.9% American Indian, 3.8% White and 15.1% other
- ➢ Tested summer/fall 2006
- ➢ Entering kindergarten or first grade

Parents of child participants *(N=53)*
- ➢ Completed questionnaires regarding life events, history, and behavior

Teachers of child participants (*N=53)*
- ➢ Completed a questionnaire during 2006-07 academic year regarding teacher-child relationship and child's academic competence

Measures

Parents and teachers:
- ➢ Health and Behavior Questionnaire (HBQ-P, HBQ-T)[6]

INSTITUTE OF CHILD DEVELOPMENT

Special Acknowledgments:
Theresa Lafavor, Amanda Wenzel, Sara Langworthy

RESULTS

Parent Ratings of Behaviors and Teacher Reports of Teacher-Child Relationship and Academic Success

Table 1.
Intercorrelations of Selected HBQ Parent and Teacher Ratings of Teacher-Child Relationship and Child Academic Competence (N=53)

Variable	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Sex	-	-.20	-.07	-.23	-.02	-.19	-.08	.19
2. Grade		-	.04	.14	-.17	.29*	.13	-.28*
3. HBQ-P Composite Externalizing			-	-.59**	-.20	-.22	.03	.32*
4. HBQ-P Composite Internalizing				-	.00	.10	.13	-.03
5. HBQ-T Academic Competence rating					-	.30*	.36**	-.12
6. HBQ-T Teacher-Child Relationship						-	.68**	-.81**
7. HBQ-T Teacher-Child Closeness							-	-.12
8. HBQ-T Teacher-Child Conflict								-

Note. ** p < .01, * p < .05

Correlations:
- Teachers reported less teacher-child conflict in children entering first grade than those entering kindergarten
- Parent reports of externalizing behaviors is positively correlated with teacher-child conflict
- There were no significant gender differences between all variables of interest

Table 2.
Do Age, Gender, and Parent Reported Behaviors Predict Teacher Reported Teacher-Child Relationship and Academic Competence? (N = 53)

	Teacher Reported Academic Competence				Teacher-Child Relationship			
	B	*SE B*	*ß*	R^2	*B*	*SE B*	*ß*	R^2
Step 1								
Constant	2.59	.34			3.74	.29		
Sex	-.07	.27	-.04		-.18	.23	-.10	
Grade	-.36	.27	-.19		.41	.22	.24†	
HBQ-P Externalizing	-.83	.45	-.32†		-.93	.38	-.39*	
HBQ-P Internalizing	.61	.52	.21		.72	.44	.27	
Total R^2				.10				.20*

Note. † = $p < .10$, * = $p < .05$

Regressions:
- Parent reports of externalizing behaviors predict teacher report of academic competence
- Parent reports of externalizing behaviors predicts quality of teacher-child relationship
- Teacher reports of children entering 1st grade predicts better teacher-child relationship than those entering kindergarten

DISCUSSION

In this study, teacher reports of children living in homeless shelters showed these children have lower academic competence and higher externalizing behaviors. This supports literature that says high risk and low socioeconomic backgrounds is correlated with lower academic success. Results demonstrated that in kindergarten there are higher amounts of conflict, but in 1st grade conflict decreases. Results also suggest that 1st graders have better relationships with their teachers. Parent reports suggest that problem behaviors at home predict the type of teacher- child relationship. Contrary to the literature, there were no significant gender differences found. Future research should investigate at risk youth and how over-regulation affects school success.

References

[6]Essex, M.J., Boyce, W.T., Goldstein, L.H., Armstrong, J.M., Kraemer, H.C., & Kupfer, D.J. (2002). The confluence of mental, physical, social, and academic difficulties in middle childhood II: Developing the MacArthur Health and Behavior Questionnaire. *Journal of the American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry, 41*(5), 588-603.
[2]McClelland, M. M., Cameron, E. C., Connor, M. C., Farris, L. C., Jewkes, M. A., & Morrison, J. F., (2007). Links between behavioral regulation and preschoolers' literacy, vocabulary, and math skills. *Developmental Psychology, 43*(4), 947-959. doi: 10.1037/0012-1649.43.4.947
[5]Obradović, J., Long, D., Cutuli, J.J., Chan, C., Hinz, E., Heistad, D., & Masten, A. (2009). Academic achievement of homeless and highly mobile children in an urban school district: Longitudinal evidence on risk, growth, and resilience. *Development and Psychopathology, 21*(2), 493. doi: 10.1017/S0954579409000273
[3]Patrick, H., Mantsicopoulos, P., Samarapungavan, A., & French, F. B. (2008). Patterns of young children's motivation for science and teacher-child relationships. *The Journal of Experimental Education, 76*(2), 121.
[1]Ready, D. D., LoGerfo, F. L., Burkam, D., & Lee, E. V. (2005). Explaining girls' advantage in kindergarten literacy learning: Do classroom behaviors make a difference? *The Elementary School Journal, 106*(1), 21.
[4]Whitney, D. S., Renner, M. L., & Herrenkohl, I. T. (2010). Gender differences in risk/protection profiles for low academic performance. *Journal of Community Psychology, 38*(4), 435.